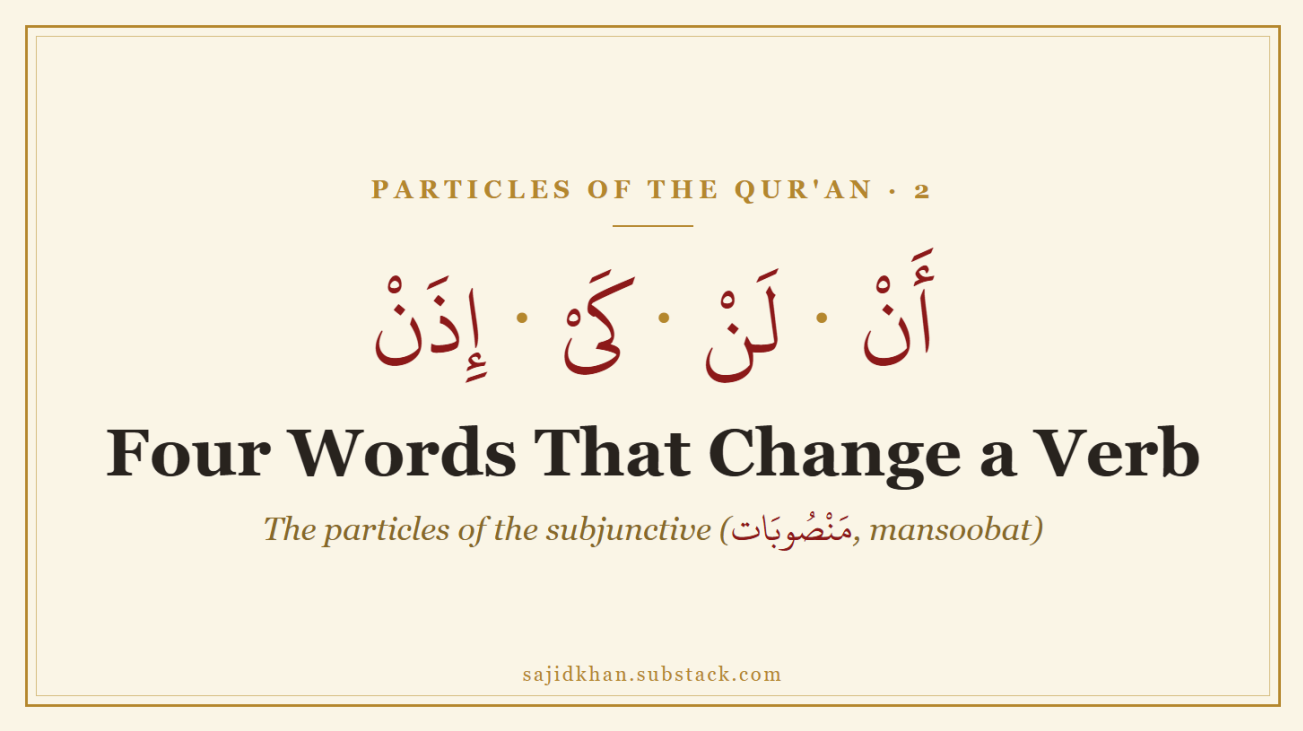


PARTICLES OF THE QUR'AN

Particles of the Qur'an 2: Four Words That Change a Verb

An, lan, kay and idhan: the particles that make a verb mansoob

Particles of the Qur'an, part 2 of 5

A present-tense verb (*fi'l mudaari'*, فِعْل مُضَارِع, "imperfect verb") normally ends in damma: يَفْعَلُ "he does". Four particles change that damma to a fatha. The verb is then in the subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب; the mood is called *nasb*, نَصْب). If the verb ends in ن (as in تَنَالُونَ "you attain"), the ن drops instead.

The four are أَنْ "that", لَنْ "will never", كَيْ "so that" and إِذَنْ "then, in that case".

1. "that": أَنْ (an)

This is the particle of the verbal noun (*harf masdariyyah*, حَرْف مَصْدَرِيَّة). With the verb after it, it works like a verbal noun: "that he does" is close to "his doing". So يَفْعَلُ "he does" becomes أَنْ يَفْعَلَ "that he does".

In the Qur'an:

أَمْ أَمِنتُم مَّن فِي السَّمَاءِ أَن يُرْسِلَ عَلَيْكُمْ حَاصِبًا

"Or do you feel safe from the One in the heaven, that He will not send against you a storm of stones?" (67:17). The verb يُرْسِلُ "he sends" has become يُرْسِلَ: it is now subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب).

2. "will never": لَنْ (lan)

A strong negative for the future. يَفْعَلُ "he does" becomes لَنْ يَفْعَلَ "he will never do".

In the Qur'an:

لَن تَنَالُوا الْبِرَّ حَتَّىٰ تُنفِقُوا مِمَّا تُحِبُّونَ

"You will never attain righteousness until you spend from what you love" (3:92). Here تَنَالُونَ "you attain" has lost its ن: تَنَالُوا, subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب). The same thing happens to تُنفِقُوا "you spend", after حَتَّىٰ "until": it is *mansoob* too.

3. "so that": كَيْ (kay)

It gives the purpose of the action. In the Qur'an it usually comes with لِ: لِكَيْ "so that".

In the Qur'an:

وَمِنكُم مَّن يُرَدُّ إِلَىٰ أَرْذَلِ الْعُمُرِ لِكَيْ لَا يَعْلَمَ بَعْدَ عِلْمٍ شَيْئًا

"And among you is one who is brought back to the weakest age, so that he knows nothing after having known" (16:70). يَعْلَمُ "he knows" has become يَعْلَمَ, subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب).

4. "then, in that case": إِذَنْ (idhan)

It answers what was said before: "if so, then...". In the Qur'an it is written إِذًا.

In the Qur'an:

أَمْ لَهُمْ نَصِيبٌ مِّنَ الْمُلْكِ فَإِذًا لَّا يُؤْتُونَ النَّاسَ نَقِيرًا ﴿٥٣﴾

"Or do they have a share of the kingdom? Then they would not give people even the speck on a date seed" (4:53).

Look closely: here the verb يُؤْتُونَ "they give" keeps its ن. It is *not* subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب). إِذَنْ only changes the verb when it starts the answer and comes straight before the verb. Here it comes after فَ "so", and لَا "not" stands between it and the verb, so it changes nothing.

Check yourself

1. What happens to تَعْلَمُونَ "you know" after لَنْ?
2. Which of the four particles is about the future only?

Answers: (1) It becomes subjunctive (*mansoob*, مَنْصُوب) and loses its ن: لَنْ تَعْلَمُوا "you will never know". (2) لَنْ "will never".

Next: the five particles that make a verb jussive, and "Inna and her sisters".

From my book Quran Grammar Summary *(second edition), section 1.5.*

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